Kyle Aaron Thompson

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Education

Auburn University — Auburn, Alabama

Ph.D. Mechanical Engineering, Minor in Aerospace Engineering — *Expected 2028*

M.S. Mechanical Engineering — *August 2025*

B.S. Mechanical Engineering, Magna Cum Laude — *August 2020*

Experience

Graduate Research Assistant – Auburn University — August 2020 – Present

GPS and Vehicle Dynamics Laboratory (GAVLAB) — *Auburn, Alabama*

- Conduct sponsored research in guidance, navigation, and control (GNC) of autonomous ground vehicles, focusing on guidance and control, with additional work on aerial platforms.
- Serve as controls, guidance, and software lead for Autonomous Tiger Racing (ATR), Auburn's Indy Autonomous Challenge (IAC) team.
- Designed raceline trajectory optimizers formulated as nonlinear programs and solved with IPOPT.
- Built real-time optimal feedback controllers as quadratic programs solved online with OSQP for reliable timing.
- Developed the majority of the team's current software stack.
- Published multiple academic papers as first author and co-authored additional conference and journal papers.

United States Marine Corps Reserves — July 2014 – Present

Gunnery Sergeant

- Oversee safe operation of M142 HIMARS rocket artillery systems for Battery K, 2nd Battalion, 14th Marines.
- Developed and taught curriculum for the professional certification of HIMARS operators.
- Deployed to Afghanistan with Task Force Southwest 19.1 and 19.2 (2019) and to Okinawa (2022–2023).

Teledyne Brown Engineering, Inc. — April 2015 – July 2015; June 2016 – August 2016

Classified Lab Administrative Assistant — *Huntsville, Alabama*

- Opened and secured the classified lab after hours and enforced government and company security policies.
- Performed basic system administration for classified lab users and supported software documentation.

Selected Publications

- **K. Thompson**, "Intelligent Emergency Stop System for Autonomous Ground Vehicles Using Minimum Jerk Trajectories and Path Tracking Linear Quadratic Regulator," *M.S. thesis*, Auburn University, Auburn, AL, Aug. 2025.
- **K. Thompson**, B. Jones, S. Martin, and D. Bevly, "GPS-Independent Autonomous Vehicle Convoying with UWB Ranging and Vehicle Models," *NDIA Ground Vehicle Systems Engineering and Technology Symposium (GVSETS)*, Novi, MI, Aug. 2022.

Skills

Guidance and Control: Classical control, LQR, MPC, trajectory optimization, path tracking, Kalman filtering
Languages: C++, Python, MATLAB; also C# (Windows), Swift (Apple), and Kotlin (Android)
Tools and Libraries: ROS/ROS 2, Qt, CasADi, IPOPT, OSQP, Git, LaTeX, and SolidWorks (3D CAD)
Computer and Software: Linux, Windows, macOS, Visual Studio, Xcode
Embedded Systems: Autonomy software on single-board computers and microcontrollers